

Creating a positive feedback cycle for your new habits

An important thing to consider is how these habits and rituals feed into and support one another. The nature of a positive feedback cycle means that, often, one good habit is the stepping stone to another, or acts as a motivating factor for other healthy habits, but also that allowing one habit to lapse can lead to a domino effect, whereby other positive habits start to topple too. Noticing the relationship between your financial habits, and also taking into account any other habits that you might have, and how they relate to your financial ones, is important, because it allows you to notice warning signs and act before things feel out of control.

I'll give you the example of yoga. I have been practising yoga intermittently since my mid-twenties, with periods where I attend classes two or three times a week and practise at home, and periods where I don't do a single pose or take a single deep breath for months on end. I started off seeing yoga as exercise – a way to burn calories, improve my flexibility and perhaps escape the noisy whirring inside my head for a short while. Purely practical. I was nervous the first day that I stepped into the studio, thinking that everyone else would be as slim, flexible and well-hydrated as I wished I was. I felt like I should have done some homework, some sort of preliminary course in how to participate. I would have quite liked to already be good at it before I set foot in this place that had been created in order to teach people how to do it.